EXCEL

Excel for Data Analysts

The functions that cover daily analyst work, plus the 2 debugging questions every interviewer asks.

- **8 functions with real examples**
- **The #N/A checklist**
- **Why SUM shows 0**

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Lookup and summarise

This is 70% of Excel work in any analyst job.

XLOOKUP

Looks left or right, handles "not found" on its own. Replaces VLOOKUP.

```
=XLOOKUP(A2, Emp[ID], Emp[Name], "Not found")
```

SUMIFS

Sum with any number of conditions.

```
=SUMIFS(Sales, Region, "North", Month, "Mar")
```

COUNTIFS

Count with conditions. Great for open tickets per owner.

```
=COUNTIFS(Status, "Open", Owner, G2)
```

IFS

Clean buckets without nesting 5 IFs.

```
=IFS(B2>=90,"A", B2>=75,"B", TRUE,"C")
```

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Clean and shape

Raw data is never clean. These save hours every week.

TRIM + CLEAN

Removes extra and invisible spaces that break lookups.

```
=TRIM(CLEAN(A2))
```

TEXTSPLIT

Split "Delhi, North, 2026" into 3 columns.

```
=TEXTSPLIT(A2, ", ")
```

UNIQUE + FILTER

Live lists that update when data changes.

```
=FILTER(Data, Data[Sales] > 50000)
```

TEXT

Turn dates into readable labels for reports.

```
=TEXT(A2, "mmm-yy")
```

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VLOOKUP shows #N/A

Interviewers ask this to see if you have worked with real data. Check in this order.

1. Hidden spaces

"A101 " and "A101" do not match. Wrap the lookup value.

```
=VLOOKUP(TRIM(A2), Range, 2, FALSE)
```

2. Number stored as text

One side is 101, the other is "101". Green triangle in the corner gives it away. Fix with VALUE or Text to Columns.

3. Range not locked

Range shifts when copied down. Use $A$2:$C$500 or a Table.

4. Missing FALSE

Without it Excel does an approximate match.

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SUM shows 0

The numbers are there, the total is 0. Three causes, in order of how often I see them.

- **Numbers stored as text**

  Left aligned, green triangle. Select the column, Data, Text to Columns, Finish.

- **Calculation is Manual**

  Someone switched it to speed up a big file. Formulas, Calculation Options, Automatic.

- **Circular reference**

  The SUM range includes its own cell. Status bar shows the cell address.

Interview tip: say the checks in order. It shows you have debugged real files, not just practised clean data.

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